



STATUS REPORT

Gambia — digital transformation and data governance status report

Edition of 2026-09-06 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The Gambia validates policy faster than it adopts it: a [Digital Government Policy and Roadmap was validated in May 2025](#) under World Bank WARDIP financing, planning a Government Service Bus and an e-government interoperability framework, and a [National Data Policy was validated in July 2025](#) covering data governance and data sovereignty. The Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy [told the National Assembly in the budget speech of 5 December 2025](#) that it had begun formulating a National AI and Emerging Technologies Policy, and [reported it still under development and not adopted](#) in April 2026. The [Government Cloud Policy](#) that accompanies the [Government Cloud Strategy 2023-2027](#) is a final draft with issue and effective dates left blank.

The [National Digital Economy Masterplan 2024-2034](#) is now the country's lead digital instrument, costing its interventions year by year — an interoperability framework at around EUR 40,000 in year two, a secure data exchange platform at around EUR 6 million, a data analytics platform at around EUR 800,000 in year three. It sits above the older [ICT4D Policy Statement 2018-2028](#), which frames eight pillars from broadband and universal access to e-government and cyber-security capability but carries no costings of its own.

The [National Broadband Policy 2020-2024](#) has run its term with no successor located, and the [strategy behind it costed nineteen action plans at D65,000,000](#) in 2020. The most recent adopted instrument is not digital at all: the country's [first unified National Land Policy 2026-2035 was published on 12 August 2026](#) after a [presidential launch on 22 December 2025](#).

On the Ibrahim Index, The Gambia [scored 54.7 out of 100 for overall governance in 2023](#), 20th of 54 African states and above the continental average, gaining 7.2 points across the decade but losing 0.1 over the most recent five years while the continent gained.

Legislation and regulation

The Gambia's first comprehensive data-protection statute reached assent on 7 November 2025, the National Assembly having [passed the Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025](#) that September; it covers biometric data, data subject rights, breach notification and data protection impact assessments. The [legislature's own bill tracker recorded the bill at "Assented"](#) as at 15 July 2026.

Telecommunications is still governed by the [Information and Communications Act 2009](#), whose [Chapter II Part XIII carries the older provisions](#) on processing personal data, privacy of communications and interception. The Communication Bill 2025, which would replace that Act and reach cybercrime, data protection and legal recognition

of electronic signatures, contracts and transactions, [passed its second reading on 3 March 2026](#) and was referred to [committee](#), members having raised surveillance-oversight questions the minister moving it did not settle on the record. As at July 2026 it [sat with the Human Rights and Constitutional Matters committee and the Education and ICT committee](#).

Most new rulemaking is arriving as ministerial instruments rather than statute. PURA [issued draft Broadcasting and Online Content Regulations 2026 on 2 April 2026 alongside six other drafts](#), made under section 226(1) of the 2009 Act — so the country's online-content rules face no second reading, committee stage or vote. Draft [enforcement regulations](#) would build a single compliance, penalty and appeal code across every regulated sector, draft [unified fees regulations](#) a single fee code, and draft [complaints and consumer-protection regulations](#) a consumer right to complain with timelines, hearings and appeals. Whether any has been made is [unestablished as at September 2026](#).

Elsewhere the pipeline is early. A [Civil Registration and Vital Statistics Bill](#) received its first reading on 5 March 2026, to replace statutes dating from 1990 and the 1880s; a [State Intelligence Service Bill](#) was cleared at a validation workshop on 31 July 2026. The [Statistics Act 2005](#) remains the constitutive statistics law, and [no general artificial-intelligence legislation was in force or before the legislature](#) as at June 2026.

Data protection

The [Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025](#) makes the Information Commission the data protection authority, with powers to investigate complaints, enter and search premises under warrant, impose administrative fines and issue enforcement notices — a single body now holding both the access-to-information mandate it was created with in 2021 and the data protection one. Controllers must [notify the Commission within 72 hours of becoming aware of a breach](#), and notify affected individuals without undue delay where the risk is high, with criminal penalties for concealment. Individuals gained [rights to access, rectify, erase and port their data with a one-month response deadline](#), though no self-service route exists through which a Gambian can see what the identity system holds on them. The Commission [took full voting membership of the Network of African Data Protection Authorities on 10 June 2026](#).

The statute closes an obligation that had stood since 2010, when [ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10](#) required each member state to establish a legal framework and an independent supervisory authority, with Article 36 permitting transfers to non-member countries only where protection is adequate and only on prior notification of that authority. The continental instrument is still outstanding: The Gambia [signed the Malabo Convention on 2 December 2022](#) and ratification and domestication remain owed.

Two gaps sit alongside the new law. Government data residency rests on a [Government Cloud Policy that is an unsigned final draft covering the government sector only](#), not a general legal localisation rule. And state access to communications is governed by nothing new: members raised the surveillance-oversight question at the [Communication Bill's second reading on 3 March 2026](#) without resolution, and the [National Intelligence Agency has been renamed the State Intelligence Service](#) ahead of a bill that had reached validation, not enactment, by 31 July 2026. Police data collection has meanwhile been running since the [WAPIS-DACORE centre was inaugurated on 14 October 2021](#) with ECOWAS, INTERPOL and the EU. On the Ibrahim Index, [protection against discrimination is the country's worst indicator of any kind, scoring 0.0 out of 100 in 2023](#) and down 8.3 points over the decade.

Regional collaboration

The Gambia lost the ECOWAS Commission's presidency on 31 August 2026, when [Omar Alieu Touray handed over to General Birame Diop of Senegal](#) after a four-year tenure, with Ghana's Amin Amidu Sulemani taking the infrastructure, energy and digitalisation portfolio at the same handover.

Roaming is where regional obligation has actually bitten. [PURA and Senegal's ARTP signed a memorandum on 15 December 2025](#) to implement the ECOWAS Community Roaming Regulation, capping voice, SMS and data charges, granting thirty consecutive free incoming-call days and setting up joint anti-fraud monitoring, with services to begin on 1 March 2026; the regulator names equivalent agreements already held with Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana, Sierra Leone and Liberia. ECOWAS ministers meeting at Cotonou had [required full implementation by all mobile operators by the end of 2025](#), and a [Lomé experts' meeting in August 2025 tracked progress through bilateral tariff agreements](#) rather than any new instrument. The wider bilateral relationship with Senegal has [moved into implementation around connectivity, cybersecurity, skills and digital transformation](#) since a June 2026 ministerial memorandum, with the two regulators separately deepening frequency coordination and quality-of-service work.

Continental commitments remain partly unfinished. The Gambia [signed the Malabo Convention at Addis Ababa on 2 December 2022](#), joining fourteen other signatory states, and undertook to ratify it so that it could be domesticated; it is [bound without transposition by ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10 on personal data protection](#), whose Article 2 requires a national legal framework and whose Article 14(1) requires an independent data protection authority. The [Information Commission won full voting membership of the Network of African Data Protection Authorities on 10 June 2026](#).

Regional machinery is thinner than the meeting schedule suggests. A [draft directive governing electronic communications in West Africa, started in 2019, was still short of adoption](#) at a September 2025 validation workshop, and the [ECOWAS Community budget for 2026-2028 carries no disaggregated digital appropriation at all](#) – the regional instruments binding The Gambia are donor-financed. The country nonetheless [scores 60.1 out of 100 on regional integration in 2023](#), 10th of 54 and up 17.4 points over the decade.

Standards

The Gambia's national standards catalogue contains [almost no ICT-specific standards](#) – its electrotechnical section consists of adopted IEC entries only, and many catalogue entries are marked draft or withdrawn and are therefore not operative. The Gambia Standards Bureau, [established by the TGSB Act 2010](#), publishes the Gambian Standards series by ICS class across management, food, building, metrology, halal, petroleum, packaging, electrotechnical, transport, and water and sanitation.

Internationally the Bureau sits at the edge of the room: it holds [ISO Correspondent membership, which carries no vote in ISO technical work](#), while participating in International Electrotechnical Commission committees at participating and observing level. It has been the country's [WTO Technical Barriers to Trade enquiry point since 2014](#). ISO's secretary-general [visited on 29-30 June 2026 and pressed the country to move from adopting international standards to contributing to them](#) by placing Gambian experts on technical committees.

Where digital standards exist they are assigned rather than written. The [National Digital Addressing Policy gives the Bureau the technical standards and GICTA the national aggregation of address data](#); GICTA's [published account of its functions under the ICT Agency Act 2019](#) claims enforcement of standards for government hardware, software and databases, custody of a national data bank and government e-signature infrastructure. The [land policy names what a digitalised land-administration system must do but sets no technical specification, data format or governing body for it](#), so no land-data standard yet exists. Regionally there is no floor to build on either: as at April 2024, ECOWAS and the EU D4D Hub had [formulated guidelines for certified electronic signatures but left the roadmap still being defined](#), so a document signed electronically in The Gambia has no regional framework obliging another member state to trust it.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The Gambia ranks [first of all 54 African states on public perception of freedom of speech](#), at 90.3 out of 100 in 2023, with digital freedom at 84.6 (5th, up 44.6 points over the decade) and media freedom at 66.8 (10th). Against that standing, the regulator is consulting on a regime that would register the people who speak.

PURA opened a public consultation on eight draft instruments by notice dated 2 April 2026, with the comment window running 1 to 10 April — nine days. Among them, [Part V of the draft Broadcasting and Online Content Regulations](#) provides for registration of designated online content providers, registration of journalists and a register of journalists, and a separate registration regime with its own application procedure for "Social Media Users with Significant Public Reach". The same draft puts content-monitoring and editorial duties on intermediaries and reaches foreign platforms, tiers online actors from internet service providers to content aggregators, establishes a Content Complaints Committee, and runs from prohibited content through political and electoral coverage to rules for live broadcasting — and it would be [made by ministerial regulation under the 2009 Act](#), with no parliamentary stage at which any of it is debated.

Civil society has organised around the one instrument that does have a parliamentary stage. Gambia Participates [convened members of the two committees handling the Communication Bill with the Gambia Press Union and the Media Council on 18 July 2026](#), where the union set out the restrictive media laws it wants repealed; members replied that they could not publicly debate a bill in committee but could carry stakeholder views into it.

The state has also entered the information-integrity business directly. The Ministry of Information's national misinformation and disinformation response centre, [Factguard](#), takes public submissions of messages, photos, videos and links by free hotline, checks them against stated evidence using trained human analysts, and publishes every determination with its sources and reasoning on a public audit trail. The [World Bank's August 2023 stakeholder engagement plan for WARDIP](#) separately sets the consultation, disclosure and grievance arrangements around the country's largest digital programme.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The most recent of The Gambia's digital memoranda put four parties on the same page over telecom tax: [the Gambia Revenue Authority, the Public Utilities Regulatory Authority, SICPA and Vista Bank signed on 15 April 2026](#) to work toward a revenue assurance system covering the mobile operators. A year earlier the government had [signed with the Kalp Foundation, in January 2025](#), to build a blockchain-based digital public infrastructure platform branded "Gambia One". India's foreign ministry [records a memorandum on digital public infrastructure cooperation signed in October 2024](#) with no funding, milestone or delivery date attached to it, alongside [the e-VBAB scholarship arrangement in place since March 2020](#) under which Gambian students study online.

Individual ministries and agencies have signed on their own account: the Accountant General's Department [with SUTURA in July 2026 on digital revenue collection](#), the Ministry of Higher Education, Research, Science and Technology [with the African Institute for Mathematical Sciences in December 2025](#) toward a satellite centre in the country, and PURA [with Senegal's ARTP toward implementing the ECOWAS community roaming regulation](#).

New investments

The Gambia's largest external commitment to its digital estate is [an IDA grant of SDR 38.1 million, US\\$50.0 million equivalent, signed on 14 December 2023 and closing on 29 December 2028](#) under the Western Africa Regional Digital Integration Program, funding PURA's regulatory work and preparation for a second submarine cable. The

country is not among the beneficiaries of [that programme's second phase](#), a US\$137 million operation announced in March 2026 for Benin, Liberia and Sierra Leone. The World Bank separately [approved US\\$160 million in IDA financing on 24 June 2026](#) for an electricity access project covering Togo and The Gambia jointly.

Two transactions dominate, both aimed at state-owned operators: YCELL's [July 2026 agreement to take an 80 per cent stake in GAMCEL with a network modernisation programme attached](#), and SYSROAD's [public-private partnership with GAMTEL](#), signed in December 2025 to modernise the national broadband network, behind which sits the [2017 China Eximbank concessional loan for the Gambia National Broadband Network](#). The government also [signed a design-build-finance-operate-transfer contract with Margins ID Systems in January 2026](#) for the national identity card. The rest is small and largely grant-funded: [the Gates Foundation's now-closed payments pilot](#), an [African Development Bank grant for unique bank identification across the West African Monetary Zone](#) and the [EU-funded DHIS2 platform tracking the national development plan](#).

Fourteen distinct commitments are on record as at September 2026, announced between September 2016 and August 2026, ten of them country-specific and four regional operations naming The Gambia as a beneficiary. Eight are grants, three concessional loans, two equity and one a public-private partnership, and eight financiers stand behind them, the African Development Bank and the World Bank most often with four and three. Connectivity draws the largest number, five of fourteen, ahead of government and e-government systems with three and digital payments with two. Most of the money is not yet moving: the largest three, led by YCELL's GAMCEL programme, are recorded as approved rather than disbursing, and the African Development Bank's DIGEST and SHyMeR operations remain at pipeline stage. The weight of it sits with the two state-owned operators.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The mobile network was renumbered on [4 September 2026](#), existing numbers taking a two-digit operator prefix — [87 for Africell, 83 for QCell, 86 for Comium](#) — while Gamcel keeps its seven-digit numbers in this phase. Reach is the older problem: the country's internet went down nationwide in the early hours of [4 June 2026](#), [after more than two weeks of electricity outages](#), with Gamtel confirming the failure and subscribers of Africell, Comium and other providers dependent on national infrastructure cut off with it.

[Just under half of Gambians used the internet in 2024, 49.5% against 45.9% a year earlier](#), and roughly two-thirds lived under a 4G signal that year. Active mobile subscriptions reached 3,484,313 in 2024, up from 3,159,599 in 2023, across seven named internet service providers — a count of SIMs, not of people. A gigabyte of mobile data cost USD 1.80 a month in 2021, 1.5% of monthly income per head and inside the affordability threshold.

Gambians' own verdict on their infrastructure has collapsed: [public perception of infrastructure scored 32.4 out of 100 in 2023, down 34.5 points since 2014 and the third most deteriorated of the country's 96 governance indicators](#). Infrastructure is the worst-scoring governance sub-category, at 33.7 out of 100 and 33rd of 54 African states, and internet and computers, up 19.7 points over the decade, still scores 26.4 and ranks 35th.

The Broadband Strategy 2020-2024 set targets of 5 Mbps for every subscriber, broadband coverage above 90% and 4G coverage above 85% by 2024, behind an action plan costed at D65,000,000. The money since has come from outside: the World Bank approved an IDA grant of SDR 38.1 million, US\$50.0 million equivalent, in November 2023 under a regional digital integration programme running to 2028 with the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy implementing, and GAMTEL signed a US\$50 million partnership with SYSROAD SA HOLDING on [24 December 2025 to modernise the national broadband network](#).

Starlink paid its licence fee in December 2024 and was still without a licence more than a year later, the minister declining a VSAT category the company does not qualify for. Domestic traffic exchange has not moved either: the Serekunda Internet Exchange Point, founded in July 2013 by fourteen members including Africell, Gamtel, QCell and PURA and hosted at Gamtel's Serekunda exchange, publishes no current capacity or participant figure.

Data Storage

The Gambia opened two data centres within three months of each other in 2026: QGroup House on Kairaba Avenue, presented as the country's first commercial facility and inaugurated by President Barrow on 29 April 2026, its tier rating and capacity undisclosed, and a purpose-built National Data Centre at Abuko, inaugurated in July 2026 and hosting the new unified National Identity Register. The Abuko facility was built and financed by the supplier Margins ID Group under a design-build-finance-operate-transfer contract rather than added to the state-managed estate.

Before them the government ran on a Tier-2 data centre managed by the state operator Gamtel, with a Tier-4 facility under consideration — and on diesel. The Government Cloud Strategy 2023-2027 records that power connectivity is not sufficient and reliable to support the country's existing data centres, naming frequent outages and voltage fluctuations as downtime and data-loss risks for that facility, which depends on diesel generator backup against electricity and cooling the same strategy records as comparatively expensive.

Where government data must sit is written down but not yet binding. The Government Cloud Policy sets a data-residency rule at its data-sovereignty section, keyed to its own data classification, requiring data classified as Classified to be stored and processed in-country on a government private cloud or on-premise; the policy remains unsigned and unenacted as at 2026, so the rule is drafted rather than in force. Outside the government sector there is no economy-wide localisation mandate at all: cross-border transfers of personal data run through an adequacy and safeguards mechanism under the 2025 data protection Act.

Energy

The Gambia was running a generation deficit exceeding half of demand in June 2026, with daily load-shedding of up to ten hours and some communities left without power for a day or more.

The National Energy Compact puts average national electricity access at 73.7% on a 2024 baseline against a target of 100% by 2030, and the average conceals the country's real division: access stood at 85.3% in urban areas against 35.3% in rural ones in 2023. 645 communities remained unelectrified (2025) and the compact identifies a US\$552 million financing gap against its universal-access trajectory (2025). Delivery leans on the grid: on-grid connection is the main path given the country's geography, mini-grids are confined to areas where extension is unfeasible, and a national tariff-equalisation policy requires subsidy for mini-grid operators. Completed access projects were inaugurated nationwide between 7 and 15 February 2026, covering 719 beneficiary communities under the GERMP, GEAP and ECOREAP programmes.

What power there is costs more than almost anywhere. The average domestic tariff is around USD 0.21 per kilowatt-hour, which the World Bank describes as among the highest in the world in dollar terms, driven by NAWEC's dependence on imported heavy fuel oil, currency depreciation and weak utility finances. Renewables account for about 13% of the overall supply mix once imported regional hydropower is counted, against a 2030 target of 30%, and for only about 1% of domestically generated electricity. Access to energy scores 31.9 out of 100 in 2023, 31st of 54 African states, up 5.4 points over the decade.

The digital estate sits on top of that. The government's own cloud strategy records power as not sufficient and reliable for the country's data centres, and the nationwide internet outage of 4-5 June 2026 arrived after more than two weeks of electricity outages.

Technical Capacity

The country's organised software developer community is small enough to count: [Google Developer Group Banjul lists fewer than a thousand members \(2026\)](#).

Civil-service capacity building was assigned by the [Civil Service Reform Programme 2018-2027](#) to the Management Development Institute; that function now sits with the [Civil Service University](#), launched in March 2026, whose [ICT department has run the country's first CISCO Networking Academy since the late 1990s](#). Formal provision beyond it is narrow: [three accredited institutions offer ICT and computer science programmes](#). Where strategy has run ahead of institutions it has done so visibly — the [E-Government Strategy 2021-2024](#) assigned delivery of an [interoperability framework to an ICT agency that had not been established when the strategy was written](#).

Administrative capability has moved in the opposite direction from the infrastructure it has to run on. [Effective administration and the capacity of the statistical system both rose sharply over 2014-2023 and now rank inside the continent's top twenty](#), while the governance category housing infrastructure, public administration and the rural economy is the one in which most sub-categories deteriorated. The statistical system's own review found [more than a third of national statistical system members unaware that the Statistics Act existed](#).

Capacity in the digital estate arrives with projects rather than with budget lines. [The WARDIP financing agreement obliges a project steering committee, a technical committee and an implementation unit inside the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy](#); the national incident-response team's [2026 staff training was delivered by the ITU and financed through the same World Bank programme rather than from domestic budget](#); and a two-week certified course in results-based management and ICT data analytics opened in July 2026, its participants expected to build and maintain dashboards afterwards.

Cybersecurity

The Gambia's binding computer-misuse and cybercrime law is still [Chapter III Part III of the Information and Communications Act 2009](#), assented in May 2009 and never displaced by a dedicated statute. A [Cybercrime Bill dated March 2024 had not been enacted as at June 2026](#), and the [Communication Bill 2025](#), which would reach cybercrime, data protection and the legal recognition of electronic signatures and contracts, stood referred to committee after its second reading on 3 March 2026.

The policy layer is in the same condition. [The National Cybersecurity Strategy covered the period 2020 to 2024](#), and cyber-security capability is one of the eight pillars of the [ICT for Development Policy Statement 2018-2028](#). Measured on declared instruments rather than tested defences, that adds up to a middling score: [61.73 out of 100 on the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024](#), in the index's 'advancing' tier.

Operationally the country has a national computer security incident response team, gmCSIRT, whose [staff were trained in May 2026 on the incident-response and threat-intelligence toolchain they are expected to operate](#), naming RTIR, T-Pot, MISP and Taranis NG, financed through the World Bank's WARDIP programme and delivered by the ITU.

Cybersecurity is one of the four priorities under which the [Senegal-Gambia telecommunications memorandum moved into implementation in 2026](#), and it heads the declared threat frame of the [State Intelligence Service](#), the renamed National Intelligence Agency, alongside espionage, disinformation and transnational organised crime.

DPI

Data Exchange

Interoperability across The Gambia's main population systems is measured at zero. The World Bank's supervision of the Resilience, Inclusion, Skills and Equity project [records a January 2024 baseline of no interoperability across the Gambia Social Registry, the education management information systems, civil registration and health insurance, and a value still of 0 at 25 November 2025 with one instance being verified, against a target of at least three systems interoperable by October 2028 carrying a US\\$500,000 performance-based allocation.](#)

There is no operational national exchange to connect them: IFMIS, ASYCUDA and Gamswitch run in silos and [data exchange is classified as planned or piloted \(October 2024\).](#) The gap is long-standing: the Ministry's own [E-Government Strategy 2021–2024, dated October 2020, states that no interoperability layer existed and assigns creation of an e-Government Interoperability Framework to an ICT agency that had not yet been established, and the strategy's implementation window closed in 2024.](#)

Work has resumed at the framework layer. The Gambia ICT Agency led [validation of a National Enterprise Architecture framework under the ITU GovStack initiative in May 2026,](#) presented as the interoperability blueprint for citizen-centric e-services; the [Digital Government Policy and Roadmap validated in May 2025 plans a Government Service Bus;](#) and the [Government Open Data Strategy 2024–2027 proposes a secure data-exchange pilot of the X-Road kind that has not been implemented.](#) None of them names an exchange in service.

The one dated exchange commitment with a named counterparty runs outward. The second Gambia–Senegal Monitoring Committee, meeting at Saly on 16–17 July 2026, [agreed to exchange customs data by API once the GAINDE system is installed at Karang, Keur Ayib and Selety within three months, to deploy SIGMAT for real-time transit tracking and to reactivate the EnCen intelligence-sharing platform.](#) Inside government the foundational links are still absent: [there is no electronic link between the national identity system and the regulator's SIM registration database, and the social registry's beneficiaries are identified by barcode rather than by national identity number.](#) The 2026 budget speech [names integration and interoperability in the payments space as a priority for the year.](#)

Digital Identity and CRVS

The Gambia replaced its national identity system in mid-2026. President Barrow [launched the National Identity Management System on 29–30 June 2026,](#) a single unified electronic National Identity Register with biometric enrolment and chip-based credentials in place of the previously fragmented ABIS and eCRVS databases, and [the first GAM ID card was issued on 6 July 2026.](#) Phase one of enrolment, for citizens aged 18 and over, began on 4 August 2026 at seven Greater Banjul centres, with a published schedule taking issuance upcountry in three tranches [between 7 and 21 September 2026.](#) The card it replaces had reached only a minority of the population (2024).

What the new credential cannot yet do is authenticate anyone online. [It supports on-card and offline verification only, with no functioning eKYC or cross-system biometric verification across government \(2026\),](#) know-your-customer checks in banking and telecoms still require the physical card under the Anti-Money Laundering and Combating of Terrorist Financing Act 2012, and manual passports remain in circulation with duplicates issued, there being [no biometric deduplication between the passport system and the identity database \(2024\).](#)

The system is privately financed. Government signed [an eight-year design-build-finance-operate-transfer contract with Margins ID Systems Applications in January 2026](#) on a 70/30 revenue share in the supplier's favour, with free replacement of all valid existing cards and [ten years of validity on the new card against the five of the old, and the](#)

register runs on a National Data Centre at Abuko inaugurated alongside it. There is no digital-identity statute: issuance rests on the National Registration Act, and the government's own strategy recommends a comprehensive law that has not been enacted (2025).

Access carries a price and an age floor. First issuance, renewal or replacement costs 450 dalasi, with no general fee waiver for vulnerable groups, and eligibility begins at 18, children being assigned a national identification number at birth through the electronic civil registration system. The credential is a dual-interface biometric ECOWAS card compliant with both ECOWAS and ICAO standards, though The Gambia is not among the states financed by the World Bank's WURI identification programme.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The Gambia got a real-time national payment rail in December 2025. BANTABA 2.0 went live on 15 December 2025, a Mojaloop-based inclusive instant payment system operated by Gamswitch that clears and settles across banks, mobile money operators, microfinance institutions and fintechs. It was built under the Gambia Interoperability Switch Programme led by the Central Bank and the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy, and the operator describes what is live as a first phase.

The money moving through the wider fintech sector is measured quarterly: cash-in rose 4.4% to D28.2 billion and cash-out 5.3% to D32.1 billion between the first and second quarters of 2026. The count of people behind it is not. The Central Bank's August 2026 Monetary Policy Committee release carries transaction values alone, with neither a registered-user nor an active-user figure, three months after the Committee itself called for further analysis of why registrations had fallen.

Five Central Bank publications between December 2025 and August 2026 give four different readings of the same registered fintech-user series, two of them issued on the same day and contradicting each other, leaving the March 2026 count unresolved.

Reach is uneven. Six commercial banks are live on the Pan-African Payment and Settlement System as at April 2026, and no Gambian mobile-money operator or wallet appears on that list. Government has begun paying and collecting through them: the Nafa cash transfer has paid bi-monthly grants to more than 15,000 rural households cashlessly through Wave since January 2026, with urban rollout confirmed in June 2026, and Yonna Wallet became the first Gambian fintech authorised to collect payments for all government services through the Accountant General's Department (March 2026).

The governing instruments lag the systems. Digital retail payments run under the Central Bank's 2011 mobile money regulation, whose section 8.1 obliges licensed providers to use systems capable of both domestic and international interoperability — a duty to be capable, not a duty to interoperate. Access to banking services is one of the country's ten worst-scoring governance indicators, at 15.4 out of 100 in 2023 and up only 1.2 points over the decade.

Registries

The Gambia's land register is on paper, and the software built to change that is not being used: a National Assembly committee found in November 2025 that a UNDP-funded digital workflow system for land administration has gone unused while the land and deeds registry under the Lands (Registration of Deeds) Act 1980 remains a manual system. It is a deeds record rather than a cadastre or parcel index. The National Land Policy 2026–2035, published in August 2026, mandates a digitalised National Land Administration System, a centralised Land Information System and digitised land registration, and the only cadastral mapping under way is a single-area pilot at Kotu Stream tendered under the WACA coastal project.

Civil registration is the working exception. The electronic Civil Registration and Vital Statistics system, launched in August 2022 on the HERA platform, replaced paper birth registration and issues digital birth certificates carrying a unique national identification number, cumulative registrations passing 1.4 million by June 2026 against 1.17 million in February 2023. Marriage and divorce registration remain a separate paper process at the Ministry of Justice (2024).

The social registry is the most used database in government. Fifteen programmes drew on the Gambia Social Registry to select beneficiaries as at November 2025, against a closing target of eight, with coverage steady at 43 districts; it held around 203,000 households, roughly 70% of the population, in 2024. It is also unconnected: beneficiaries are identified by barcodes and QR codes issued for cash transfers rather than by national identity number, and the Social Security and Housing Finance Corporation keeps its own separate seven-digit identifier.

The other registers sit apart from one another too. Business registration runs online through the Single Window Registry under the Single Window Business Registration Act 2013. The Independent Electoral Commission maintains a mature, continuously updated nationwide biometric voter register, which is kept entirely separate from the new National Identity Management System with no documented data-sharing between them while a fresh biometric registration exercise runs to October 2026. And the digital address register is linked to no other government system, the land and deeds register included (2025).

Sectoral management information systems

Domestic tax administration was still largely manual as at June 2026, the Integrated Tax Administration System having reached taxpayer sensitisation but not rollout, so e-registration, e-filing and e-payment are not live. The build has already survived a supplier failure: the contract was first awarded to SOGEMA Technologies of Canada, which went bankrupt before delivery, after which an Arabsoft and Tunisie Micro-Informatique consortium was engaged at USD 7,270,192.20 in October 2025 – a 24-month build designed to interoperate with the Central Bank, the Accountant General's Department, the Companies Registry, the national identity system and ASYCUDA World.

Customs is the digitised end of revenue. The deployed stack comprises ASYCUDA World for clearance, a National Single Window, automated weighbridges, OCR cameras at all entry and exit points and a traceability solution using electronically verifiable excise stamps (March 2026), alongside a Digital Tax Invoicing System launched in July 2025.

The sectoral systems are further along than the links between them. The Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education has run a DHIS2-based education management information system since 2018 and the SEMIS App was scaled nationally by 2021, capturing learner data on offline-capable devices; the Health Management Information System identifies patients by the national identification number generated at civil registration; and the two ministries signed a memorandum of understanding in July 2026 to link them, with the integration not yet operational. Immunisation data is still written by hand at the health facility and scanned at regional centres (2025).

Policing has no records system at all. The Inspector General of Police confirmed publicly in March 2026 that the force still documents its work on paper, and its own arrest and detention procedure prescribes paper instruments alone, naming no digital case-recording tool. Elsewhere a DHIS2-based platform tracking the national development plan across ministries was built with European Union funding of EUR 493,346, covering 237 indicators across the plan's seven pillars, and a Labour Market and Migration Information System mandated by the Labour Act 2023 was connected to five regional job centres but not yet fully operational in April 2026.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Gambians can pay the state digitally sooner than they can transact with it. Yonna Wallet became the first Gambian fintech authorised to collect payments for all government services through the Accountant General's Department, with auto-generated traceable receipts and a channel for diaspora payments (March 2026), and work is under way on a GovPay platform to bring public-sector payments across ministries onto one monitored channel. The government's own account of why 2025 non-tax revenue reached only 66% of target, at D4.05 billion, named the absence of digital payment systems among the reasons.

Delivery of the services themselves is thinner. The government portal at gambia.gov.gm points users to services such as identity card, birth certificate, business registration and passport applications rather than transacting them (2024). The Gambia scored 0.2552 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, ranking 181st and placing it in the index's low group, and Gambians rate obtaining an identity document at 38.4 out of 100 in 2023, 21st of 54 African states and up only 7.8 points over the decade.

Where services have been digitised they are single-agency. Business registration runs online through the Single Window Registry; customs runs a full digital stack while domestic tax administration remained largely manual as at June 2026; the judiciary is digitising through a computer-aided recording and transcription system with an electronic case management system still at feasibility study and no integration to any wider government data exchange; and there is no land information system, an assessment having been conducted to evaluate structures for one with no build, procurement, budget or timetable dated (March 2026). Marriage and divorce registration remain paper.

The institutional machinery is being assembled ahead of the services. A National Digital Addressing Steering Committee was launched in October 2025, the Gambia ICT Agency led validation of a National Enterprise Architecture framework under the ITU GovStack initiative in May 2026, and the Ministry of Information runs Factguard, a national misinformation and disinformation response centre that takes public submissions through a free hotline and has them checked by trained human analysts against stated evidence.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Whether the state's financial management system works at the country's largest council is in open dispute between two arms of government: in August 2026 the Accountant General's Department publicly rejected Kanifing Municipal Council mayor Talib Bensouda's account of the council's use of the Integrated Financial Management Information System, offering ledgers and expenditure reports it had generated for the council as evidence the system is in use there.

Sub-national digital government otherwise rests on a single instrument. The National Digital Addressing Policy (2023) makes local governments the custodians of digital addresses and of their own local address databases rather than consumers of a nationally held dataset, requires each to operate a local digital address portal carrying region-wide spatial data, and provides for those local databases to be shared with a national database held by the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy, with national aggregation falling to the Gambia Information and Communication Technology Agency and technical standards to the Gambia Standards Bureau.

One council has built to it. Kanifing has tied digital address codes, built on Google Plus Codes and displayed on compound gates, to properties' geographic coordinates and into its municipal property-rates register, and its rates manager said collectors now work from tablets that navigate to a registered property by its address rather than by the owner's name (June 2026). The council expects the codes to improve emergency response and rates collection,

and is adding street numbering alongside them. The register stops at the council boundary: it is [not linked to any other government system, including the land and deeds register](#), and [extension beyond Kanifing to Banjul and parts of the West Coast Region](#) was still under way in 2025.

The programmes that carry the country's digital government — the digital economy masterplan and the national identity system — are [designed and administered at national level, with local government outside their data-exchange arrangements](#) (2024). Separately, the [Greater Banjul Area Sustainable Urban Development Programme 2020-40](#) is supported by an African Development Bank Transition Support Facility grant covering capacity building and implementation of the [Greater Banjul Digital Master Plan](#).

Rural digital data capture

Rural health data is still captured on paper where the patient is: the immunisation programme's [Smart Paper Technology](#) has [forms completed by hand at the point of care and scanned and digitised at regional centres](#), so the digital step happens above the facility, not at it, and [rural primary clinics record patient data on paper](#), with point-of-care entry confined to a tablet pilot alongside the paper registers (2025). Civil registration is the exception: the Ministry of Health has [replaced the paper system with an electronic one and extended satellite internet to health facilities including rural ones](#), which the [2026 budget speech](#) ties to birth registration rather than care (December 2025).

The [National Digital Economy Masterplan 2024-2034](#) concentrates digital infrastructure and services in Greater Banjul and treats rural connectivity — a secondary submarine cable and village hubs — as a priority still to be delivered. The rural economy those services would reach [scored 57.8 out of 100 in 2023, 29th of 54 African states](#); access to markets, physical and institutional, fell 13.7 points over the decade to 63.0, its sharpest-falling component. Rural [electricity access remains far below the urban rate](#) (2023), which bounds what a village facility can run.

Education is the one sector built for the offline case. The ministry has run a [DHIS2-based education management information system since 2018](#), whose teacher attendance component reports by structured SMS where there is no connectivity, and the [SEMIS school system captures learner data on offline-capable devices](#) (2025). It earns its keep: [few schools have internet for teaching or computers to teach on, and many lower basic schools have no electricity](#) (2025).

Policing has had no such design: the [Inspector General of Police said in March 2026 that the force still documents its work on paper](#), and its [arrest and detention manual prescribes paper instruments alone](#) — the station diary, the pocket diary, the Diary of Action.

Three digital policing programmes are on record — a 2021 West African Police Information System commitment, a 2026 automated fingerprint identification milestone and a 2025 case-management result — and none puts digital capture at a rural police post.

Technology

AI

The most visible artificial-intelligence initiative in Gambian government does not claim to use artificial intelligence. The [National Misinformation and Disinformation Response Centre's own public site](#) describes a process of [human analyst review](#), and the centre was [launched on 27 April 2026 with ECOWAS funding, built by the Gambian firm Dundal Systems and organised around three pillars — detect, verify, respond](#).

Behind that, the state has little to run models on. There was no operational analytics or artificial-intelligence capability in government data systems as at 2024, and no data exchange into which such a capability could be integrated; the national digital economy masterplan budgets a data analytics platform at around EUR 800,000 in its third year, a costing the plan has not attached to money.

The one scheduled public-sector use is unfunded on its own face. The Gambia Revenue Authority's 2025-2029 corporate strategic plan sets project IE06 to pilot big data, cloud computing, AI, machine learning, IoT and APIs in 2026-2027 at D10.4 million, under a cost column headed "project cost (not funded)".

Nothing in law reaches the technology directly. No general AI legislation was in force as at June 2026, no AI legislation was proposed, and there were no dedicated rules on risks such as hallucination or deepfakes; the same assessment maps AI-adjacent data handling onto the constitutional privacy and fair-trial guarantees, the Criminal Procedure Code 1993 and the data-protection statute as the closest applicable framework. The national AI policy and strategy was still under development when the communications ministry addressed the UN Commission on Science and Technology for Development in April 2026.

Use is running ahead of both. Gambia Participates' founder reported AI-generated images being used to build false narratives during the supplementary voter-registration exercise (June 2026), and the same donor-funded programme has trained journalists and fact-checkers in Kololi in using AI to debunk. Teaching capacity sits at the University of The Gambia, whose ICT school runs a six-month diploma in artificial intelligence alongside data science and cybersecurity.

ICT Industry

The sector shrank while the investment announcements grew: Gambian ICT gross value added fell between 2023 and 2024, from around 3.5% of GDP to around 2.4%, with sector employment of 2,922 in 2024.

Ownership of the operators is changing at the same time. The state is divesting 80 per cent of GAMCEL, its mobile operator, to YCell, and the share investment and network modernisation agreement was signed in July 2026, covering nationwide 4G and 5G radio access, core network, OSS/BSS and billing systems, hybrid power at tower sites and fraud management. GAMTEL separately entered a public-private partnership with SYSROAD SA HOLDING to expand core network capacity (January 2026).

Private capital has also built what the state did not: the country's first data centre, QGroup House, was inaugurated in April 2026 by a domestic operator with Huawei as long-term vendor. What the industry has to build to is thin – the standards bureau's catalogue carries almost no ICT-specific standards, its electrotechnical section consisting of adopted IEC entries only (2022) – and so is the labour pool, with the Banjul Google Developer Group counting fewer than a thousand members (2026). A draft e-commerce policy and strategy reached a national validation workshop on 24 September 2025 under World Bank WARDIP support.

Innovation ecosystem

The Gambia does not appear in the international innovation measures at all: it is in none of the 133 economies profiled in the Global Innovation Index 2024, nor in the 2019-2023 editions.

The domestic startup base is small and largely private. AfriLabs lists three active technology hubs – The Disruptive Lab, Gambia Tech and Startup Incubator Gambia (2026), alongside the older Banjul vocational training and incubation centre handed over by India in 2017, which teaches ICT among its disciplines. Tracxn lists 185 Gambian startups, seventeen of them funded and most in banking and fintech, and records no material venture funding rounds for the country (2026).

Government support is at the framework stage. The [December 2025 budget speech](#) named a Digital Startups Policy, a National Data Policy and a Digital Government Policy and Roadmap among the instruments government said it was strengthening, none of them dated or cited to a gazette in the speech. The most ambitious commitment of the period remains a memorandum: a [January 2025 agreement with the Kalp Foundation](#) to build a blockchain-based digital public infrastructure platform branded "Gambia One".

Capacity

Literacy

Only 13.2% of Gambian schools had internet access for teaching in 2025, 15.6% had computers for pedagogical use and 57% of lower basic schools had electricity. The Education Sector Policy 2016–2030 commits the school system to teaching programming, database design, website administration and network-systems administration, and to integrating ICT into teaching and learning generally; the distance between that commitment and those three figures is the country's school digital-literacy position as at September 2026.

The same policy carries no count of schools with working ICT laboratories, no connectivity figure and no count of ICT-qualified teachers, so the central curricular commitment runs without a delivery baseline against which any of it can be measured. School ICT access also sits as one strand of a whole-sector policy rather than in a dedicated chapter or a standalone school connectivity programme.

Education is nonetheless one of The Gambia's three best-scoring governance sub-categories, at 61.8 out of 100 in 2023 and 11th of 54 African states, with education quality at 57.4. On the same index for 2023, enrolment scores 48.5 and completion 58.3, both up around ten points over the decade, leaving enrolment below the halfway mark against African peers even as it climbs.

Outside the curriculum, an artificial-intelligence education app was launched for Gambian schools in November 2025 by Africa Missions Global, a faith-based NGO working with the Ministry of Basic and Secondary Education as partner, offering students registration on an artificial-intelligence course. In financial services, the Central Bank's National Financial Inclusion Strategy carries a financial literacy and consumer protection working group and a gender-sensitive consumer protection framework aimed at women and youth.

Training and skills

The Civil Service University's School of ICT and Digital Governance was launched on 30 March 2026, its ICT department succeeding that of the Management Development Institute, the body the Civil Service Reform Programme 2018–2027 names as responsible for building civil-service capacity, and running since the late 1990s as the country's first CISCO Networking Academy. That reform programme provides for ICT training across ministries, a human-resource management information system, e-government and systematic closure of civil-service capacity gaps, and runs to 2027.

The National Accreditation and Quality Assurance Authority names eleven institutions accredited to offer degrees, among them the University of The Gambia, the Civil Service University and the University of Applied Science, Engineering and Technology, and warns that unaccredited degrees are not recognised by government. The University of The Gambia's School of Information, Technology and Communications offers BSc degrees in Computer Science, Information Systems and Telecommunications, alongside six-month diplomas in networking and cloud, web development, data science, cybersecurity, artificial intelligence and advanced web applications. The teaching workforce is the strongest part of the system that feeds it: human resources in education scored 88.0 out of 100 in 2023, 20th of 54 African states.

None of the degree-granting institutions with dedicated ICT provision publishes enrolment or graduation figures for those programmes, and none of the foreign channels supplying Gambians with digital and technical places publishes completion or placement data.

Most training that is counted at all is donor-delivered and small. Nearly 300 law-enforcement officers had been trained on the automated fingerprint identification system through a pool of ten national trainers by May 2026. Twenty-five planners from more than ten government institutions were trained on demographic modules, software and databases in August 2026. More than twenty health staff were trained on event-based surveillance signal detection and reporting over two days in December 2025, with surveillance reporting still a live capacity gap at the workshop's close. India has awarded 302 scholarships to Gambian students for online undergraduate, postgraduate and diploma study since March 2020.

Research institutions

The Ministry of Higher Education, Research, Science and Technology signed a memorandum with the African Institute for Mathematical Sciences at Mbour on 10 December 2025 to establish an AIMS satellite centre in The Gambia, with a stated roadmap towards an autonomous centre of excellence. Its scope covers access for Gambian students to AIMS postgraduate programmes in mathematical sciences, data science and artificial intelligence at the network's centres in Senegal, Rwanda and South Africa, training for Gambian university lecturers and secondary-school teachers, collaborative research and shared access to datasets and technological resources.

Domestic computing research capacity rests on the University of The Gambia's ICT school and its three undergraduate degree programmes. The most substantial recent applied research on the labour market comes instead from the Gambia Bureau of Statistics' trend volume covering 2023 to 2026, which was financed by the World Bank through the HISWACA project with ILO technical support rather than from domestic budget.

Inclusion

Access to services

Inclusion and equality is The Gambia's only top-ten governance sub-category, at 62.8 out of 100 and 10th of 54 African states in 2023 after a 14.5-point gain over the decade, with equal access to public services at 55.6 and 13th of 54. What is distributed evenly is nonetheless thin: access to banking sits among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators.

The Persons with Disabilities Act 2021 addresses information and communications in general terms and sets no digital or web accessibility standard. A framework for monitoring the Act, accessibility included, was validated in February 2026. Assistive equipment comes from outside government: Ecobank Gambia handed a refurbished ICT laboratory of fifteen machines running the NVDA screen reader to the Gambia Organization of the Visually Impaired on 11 October 2025.

Cash transfer reach is widening. The Nafa programme moved into 10 new districts in November 2025, with nationwide expansion planned for 2026, paying rural households cashlessly through a mobile money platform since January 2026, with urban rollout confirmed in June 2026, off the national social registry.

PURA's toll-free 148 call centre, with a documented complaint-handling and escalation flow, is the operative statutory feedback route for regulated utilities, and no single national citizen-feedback platform stands above it. Draft regulations giving consumers a right to complain, with timelines, escalation, hearings, appeals and protection against retaliation, went out for comment in April 2026 and are not in force.

The National Migration Policy 2020-2030 is the standing framework for refugees, statelessness, non-discrimination, identity documents, border management and migration data, with a dedicated chapter on each, above the Refugee Act 2008's statutory entitlement to a refugee identity card and Convention travel document. UNHCR recorded 4,214 people of concern at 31 May 2026.

The Universal Access and Service Policy 2020 created a Universal Access and Service Fund and Board and directed priority to rural communities, women, youth, persons with disabilities, schools and health facilities, its headline commitment universal broadband coverage within three years of 2020. School ICT access is one strand of the whole-sector Education Sector Policy 2016-2030 rather than a dedicated chapter or a standalone connectivity programme.

Digital divides

The size of The Gambia's digital gender gap is not published. The National Gender Policy 2025-2034 names the digital gender divide as a problem but puts no figure on it, so the country's principal gender instrument carries no measure of the gap it commits to closing, and GSMA's Mobile Gender Gap Report 2025 does not survey the country. The policy is otherwise substantial: dated June 2024 and funded by the African Development Bank, it succeeds the expired Gender and Women Empowerment Policy 2010-2020 and carries the constitutional and legislative provisions, the ratified global and regional instruments, and a situational analysis running across economic development, gender-based violence, education, health, justice and governance.

Measurement is arriving from outside. The World Bank released Gambian microdata from the Global Findex Database 2025 on 1 October 2025, drawn from 2024 fieldwork and adding nationally representative readings of mobile ownership, internet use, digital safety and account access alongside a new Digital Connectivity Tracker; the Bank also publishes a Gambia Gender Data Landscape setting gender-equity indicators against regional and income-group peers. The national accounting does not answer the question: the Bureau of Statistics' communication statistics report gives mobile subscribers only, with no internet subscription count or penetration rate.

The divide that is measured is geographic. Digital infrastructure and services are concentrated in the Greater Banjul urban area, with rural connectivity — a secondary submarine cable and village hubs — treated in the national digital economy masterplan as a priority still to be delivered. The services that digital access rests on show the same shape, in the gap between urban and rural electricity access and in the small minority of schools with internet for teaching or computers for pedagogical use.

Intervention on the gender divide is recent and thin. In October 2025 the Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy launched a project with the Digital Cooperation Organization to support women-owned small businesses with digital skills, e-commerce and financial inclusion.

Data

National statistics

Statistical capacity is one of The Gambia's fastest-improving governance measures, scoring 60.1 out of 100 in 2023, 14th of 54 African states after a 33.8-point rise over the decade, the seventh most improved of its 96 indicators. The gain is uneven: on the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators the country scores above 89% on data use but only 20-49% on data sources (2023), the pillar covering the censuses, surveys and administrative records everything else is built from. Three or more household, health and labour force surveys have been fielded in the last ten years, but no agricultural survey and no business survey, leaving the productive economy the least surveyed part of the system.

Output has quickened. GBoS published the [National Food Security Survey Report 2026](#) in May 2026, covering all eight Local Government Areas, and the fifth round of the Labour Force Survey in July 2026. That round puts the working-age population at 1,434,115, employment at 733,364 and the unemployment rate at 6.2% (March 2026), with underutilisation far above the headline, at LU3 23.6% and LU4 32.1%. Both it and the bureau's three-round comparison were funded by the World Bank through HISWACA, with ILO technical support, so the flagship series rests on donor money.

The governance layer has not kept pace. NSDS III, published September 2023, concedes weaknesses in coordination, in modernisation and in data sharing and protection, and records that 35.3% of members of the national statistical system were unaware the Statistics Act 2005 existed. STATAFRIC's peer review of 17 November 2025 names modernising the statistical legal framework among the areas requiring sustained attention, while crediting dissemination through the IMF's enhanced General Data Dissemination System and a National Summary Data Page. The Act itself sits in the bureau's library as an image-only scan with no text layer, unreadable as published.

Communication Statistics 2024, dated June 2025, reports mobile subscribers only, carrying no internet subscription count or penetration rate despite a section headed for them, and published electricity access figures are estimates rather than survey results, with a Multi-Tier Framework survey committed under the National Energy Compact (2025).

Open data

The Gambia's own [Government Open Data Strategy 2024-2027](#) states that government has no legal framework for open data, no centralised registry and no data-quality software (2024) — and that the missing legal framework has inhibited data sharing even between government bodies, the most candid official statement on file of that gap. The strategy was formulated with the e-Governance Academy and sets its KPI targets against 31 December 2026; the secure data-exchange pilot of the X-Road kind it proposes remains unimplemented. It was put in place by the [Ministry of Communications and Digital Economy for 2024 to 2027](#).

Across the twenty-three Open Data Inventory categories assessed for The Gambia in 2024 the country averages 4.2 out of 10, with three categories at zero and only seven reaching 5.5 or above.

The zeros are [telecommunications and digital statistics](#), [energy statistics](#), and [crime and justice statistics](#), each scoring nothing out of ten in the 2024 assessment. Social and health categories score little better: [health facilities](#) 3 out of 10, [health outcomes](#) 3.5, [population](#) 4 and [education facilities](#) 4 (2024). The strength is financial and macroeconomic — [balance of payments](#), [government finance](#) and [price indexes](#) each score 7, and [banking statistics](#) 6.5 (2024) — which is the profile of a system whose publishing habits answer to external surveillance rather than to domestic demand.

The statutory basis is in place; the practice is not. The [Access to Information Act 2021](#) gives Gambians a right to request public records and created the Information Commission, which now also serves as the country's data protection authority. Against that, [Disclosure of Public Records](#) scores 27.1 out of 100 in 2023, 36th of 54 African states, and [Accessibility of Public Records](#) 29.7, both among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators after a decade of improvement. The Commission is procuring a communication strategy to raise public awareness of that Act and of the [Personal Data Protection and Privacy Act 2025](#), funded by UNFPA under the Peacebuilding Fund (August 2026).

Use of satellite data

The national meteorological service took delivery of [Meteosat Third Generation PUMA and ClimSA satellite reception stations on 30 August 2024](#), giving the Department of Water Resources direct access to EUMETSAT feeds. The upgrade arrived as project delivery rather than national procurement: the stations were [supplied under the EU-funded ClimSA programme and contracted by the African Union to the Swiss firm Tecnavia](#).

The geospatial platform in use for Gambian land and agriculture is likewise a donor's. [FAO's 2024 monitoring framework for the ROOTS project documents a platform tracking rice, vegetable gardens, mangroves, forestry, agroforestry and infrastructure through a National Land Cover Reference System](#), used for agricultural and natural-resource planning. Regionally, [the European Space Agency's Global Development Assistance programme, with the Sahara and Sahel Observatory, is building a Sentinel-1 and Sentinel-2 demonstrator for rice-area mapping and productivity comparison for RICOWAS, an Adaptation Fund programme spanning thirteen West African countries and about 125,000 farmers, The Gambia among them \(July 2026\)](#).

Satellite capability also turns up where it would not be looked for. The [2026 budget speech reports satellite internet installed in health facilities specifically to improve birth registration rates](#), naming connectivity as the lever for a civil-registration outcome rather than for care delivery, and the [national Early Warnings for All roadmap endorsed in October 2025](#) sets the country's multi-hazard coverage ambition.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

United States engagement with The Gambia's digital sector runs almost entirely through one company, and it has turned into friction: the government has publicly characterised its handling of Starlink's application as [due diligence conducted despite United States pressure](#) (July 2025), with the licence still unissued.

It began cordially and at ministerial level. The Foreign Ministry recorded a [virtual meeting between Foreign Minister Mamadou Tangara and Elon Musk](#) on bridging the digital divide, followed by an in-person meeting in Banjul on 23 July 2024 with Starlink's director of global licensing and activation, Ben MacWilliams, who also met the leadership of PURA and the minister then responsible for the sector. Nothing in that engagement committed either side to anything, and the two years since have been spent on a licence rather than on a deployment.

China activities

The clearest Chinese presence in The Gambia's digital build is commercial rather than sovereign: [Huawei is the long-term vendor behind QGroup House](#), the privately built facility opened in April 2026 that holds the country's first data centre and was presented as Gambian-owned innovation.

State to state, the record is a debt. A [China Eximbank concessional loan signed in December 2017 for the national broadband network](#) was on-lent to the state operator GAMTEL and secured against a cash balance the lender could reach. It did not sit lightly on the public finances: the borrowing [took the government through its ceiling on contracting new non-concessional external debt](#), and GAMTEL fell into arrears on interest before being required to maintain and replenish a dedicated escrow account to service it.

China's own account of its role is broader than anything the record carries. The embassy in Banjul [names the National Broadband Network and 5G networks among the projects Chinese companies undertake in the country](#) (October 2023) without naming a company, a contract, a value or a completion date for any of them.

EU activities

The European Union is the largest declared external funder of The Gambia's public digital systems and has never sized that work. Its [EUR 193 million grant envelope for 2021–2027 under the Global Gateway strategy](#) carries [no digital-specific figure](#), and digitalisation reaches the Commission's own statement of the programme as a single clause — enabling digitalisation in business and public administration — [with no project or instrument attached to it](#) (September 2026).

What has been sized is small and precise. [EUR 493,346 of EU funding built a DHIS2-based web platform tracking 237 indicators across the seven pillars of the Recovery-Focused National Development Plan](#), with real-time collection, analysis and reporting across ministries, departments and agencies and training for the transition to programme-based budgeting (April 2026).

The larger visible delivery is policing infrastructure rather than administration. The Gambia's [criminal Automated Fingerprint Identification System went live on 28 April 2026](#) under the EU-funded, INTERPOL-implemented WAPIS programme, with renovated Criminal Records Office premises and several hundred officers trained around it, and [no cost figure has been published for the EU's funding of it](#) (May 2026), so the size of that commitment cannot be established.

Cooperation runs on a [Multiannual Indicative Programme for 2021–2027, amended at mid-term review on 31 October 2024](#), with annual action plans for 2022, 2023 and 2024, and the envelope is grouped under [five headings — democratic transition, sustainable growth and jobs, energy, human development and migration management](#); none of them is digital. European money also sits under pieces of the data estate counted elsewhere in this report: the [Meteosat and ClimSA reception stations delivered to the Department of Water Resources](#), the [peer review of the national statistical system](#) implemented by Expertise France, and the [National Digital Addressing Policy developed with the AU-EU Digital for Development Hub and Estonia's eGovernance Academy](#).

Gulf/UAE activities

Gulf-linked financing of Gambian connectivity runs through a multilateral bank rather than a state: the [Islamic Development Bank counts The Gambia among the beneficiaries of the ECOWAS fibre optic backbone it financed](#), providing national fibre infrastructure and cross-border connection with neighbouring countries in cooperation with the African Development Bank and the World Bank, though its account names no date, sum or contractor for the Gambian leg.

India activities

India's involvement in Gambian digital public infrastructure exists on paper and, so far, nowhere else: New Delhi's own [brief on relations with The Gambia records a memorandum of understanding on digital public infrastructure cooperation signed in October 2024](#), with no funding, milestone or delivery date attached to it.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/GMB/GMB-status.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/GMB/GMB-status-2026-09-06.pdf
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